

Brookline Solid Waste Advisory Committee

Meeting Minutes for May 10, 2022

Minutes submitted by Kaity Robbins

The meeting came to order online via Zoom at 6:30 pm

Attendees:

SWAC Members: John Dempsey (chair), Deane Coady, Mary Litterst, Susan Rittling, Kaity Robbins

SWAC Members absent: Kathleen O'Connell, Clint Richmond

DPW Staff: Kevin Johnson, Katie Weatherseed, Chaimaa Medhat, John King

Members of the Public: Diana McClure, Geri Lambert, Bob Jones, Amie Lindenboim. Sheera Hefter, Mary Sabolsi, Pamela Allara, Lily Yu, Julia Herskowitz, Michael McGraw-Herdeg, Nicola Thompson

Welcome to Katie Weatherseed

SWAC welcomed Katie Weatherseed to the newly created position of Zero Waste Program Manager. Katie was the Conservation Assistant for four years so she is not new to DPW. She has a background in program management in climate resiliency. Her position is funded by a grant for three years.

Approval of minutes of March 1 and April 5, 2022,

The minutes of both meetings were approved unanimously.

DPW Report – Chaimaa Medhat

Chaimaa Medhat will update the April tonnages and publish them on the website.

1617 residents currently subscribe to Black Earth Compost. April school tonnage was 6.2. The reduction from March was because of April school vacation. BHS is 1 ton per week, aggregated with others is 2 tons. Ms. Coady asked if we could get Brookline commercial food waste tonnage information? Ms. Coady asked about the impact of the November 2022 plan to lower the DEP threshold to ½ ton of food waste disposed/week/facility in November 2022.

Ms. Rittling pointed out that Black Earth is diverting 1.5% of total waste tonnage.

The ACR for April 2022 is \$12.56 compared to the April 2021 ACR of \$50.50.

HHW Drop-Off

Ms. Medhat reported that HHW Drop-Off started Tuesday, May 3. Steady flow of residents. Mostly light bulbs, electronics, aerosols, paint. Tracking who is coming and the categories of their waste. Patrick O'Neill is the new Environmental Health Officer.

DPW Staffing Overview - Katie Weatherseed

Katie Weatherseed spoke about the key players in Sanitation. There have been many changes. 67 full time employees. 13 sanitation staff. Mr. Johnson supervises highway, sanitation, and fleet maintenance. Alexandra Vecchio, Parks and Open Space Director, supervises Zero Waste

Program and DPW sustainability projects. Environmental Health Supervisor/Municipal Waste Collection Manager position is open because of the retirement of Ed Gilbert and is being advertised. Patrick O'Neill, DPW, Environmental Health and Safety Officer. Chaimaa Medhat, Assistant Recycling Coordinator, also makes sure snow removal requests and violations go to the right person. Katie Weatherseed is the Zero Waste Program Manager. John King is Environmental Health Specialist. Mr. Johnson said the ZWM position was long needed. DPW is bringing some of these priorities to the top.

Education and Enforcement – John King

John King is the Environmental Health Specialist (i.e. Education and Enforcement Officer). He took over the role about 5 years ago. He said he is both complaint-driven and keeping an eye out for problems. He knows some problem properties. Some days complaints are coming in, some days he's driving around making sure things are up to code. "BrookOnline is a decent system. If I can't get a hold of someone, I write the ticket. Often properties are owned by someone out of town, so tickets are ineffective. I have compiled phone numbers so I can contact them immediately. Personal relationship building seems to be effective! Most landlords and property managers get it."

Ms. Coady asked about violations on Boylston Street. The violating units are owned by individuals. Hard to get accountability. Mr. King goes through bags looking for addresses. Wed/Thurs he goes up and down Bolyston with expectation of violations.

If there are neighbors who don't ever put recycling out notify DPW and Mr. King will investigate. As for fines: warning first, fine second. Fines carry over for 6 months. 1-3 family house is \$25, 35, 55 – multifamily is \$100, 200, 300. \$300 is max. Can also write a fine for obstruction of public property (\$300). Fines have not changed since 1998. They are regulated by state law. If there are continued problems within 6 months, you can bring them to court and terminate public service. The supervisor of sanitation routes (orange pickup truck) doesn't write tickets, but gives warnings for common issues. He will report problems to Mr. King.

Ms. Coady raised the question of residents putting recyclables in with their trash. Mr. King said that that is always going to be a problem. He has sat down with some property managers and their tenants to go over the rules. He distributes brochures to the larger buildings. Part of the problem is turnover and proximity to Boston. It's going to come down to education. He thinks Brookline is pretty on-point with sorting. Mr. Johnson said it's going to be very hard to identify problem residents because all their trash is sealed in a trash bag which is what our bylaw requires. We allow them to put loose recycling in so it's easier to catch contamination of recycling than it is to catch them putting recycling in their trash. Education is our best weapon.

Ms. Litterst asked for a copy of the violation form to help frame discussions within buildings.

Education is mostly given when there is an infraction. Some property managers reach out asking to be more proactive with education to tenants. DPW does put out newsletters periodically and have started including composting.

Black Earth Compost Incentive discussion – Katie Weatherseed

Katie Weatherseed spoke about DPW's incentive program to get more Black Earth Compost subscribers. Free starter kit. (\$38 value) Launched at Spring Fest on May 7th. Paid for with \$5000 from the DPW budget. Ten residents signed up that day. Will continue to advertise over the next few weeks. Ms. Rittling suggested that DPW consider doing the same for kitchen bins in the future. Mr. Dempsey asked about incentives for those in Section 8 housing. Will reach out to the monthly Housing Authority newsletter. DPW will have an educational table at town events. The program will take us to July 2022; hoping to be able to do another \$5k next FY.

Update on Composting Task Force - Kathleen O'Connell/Susan Rittling

Kathleen O'Connell and Susan Rittling reported the task force is meeting routinely on the third Tuesday of the month. They've been working on an outline. Met last week with Katie Weatherseed and Alexandra Vecchio. Ms. Weatherseed is the primary DPW task force rep. Will help fill the knowledge gap and focus our inquiries. A question to be answered: Is it competitive to keep curbside composting in house or does it make more sense to outsource? For recycling, it proved beneficial to outsource. For Hybrid PAYT, analysis showed it was competitive to stay in house. One of our priorities is having the task force conduct cost benefit analysis. Ms. Rittling said the task force has divided the universe into two areas: gathering info and promoting Black Earth. Ms. Coady asked if every-other-week trash collection could be feasible?

A PFAS Info Repository? – Mary Litterst

Mary Litterst asked if we should have a place where information can be stored regarding different issues? If we need to pull out info to back up why we said XYZ, where can we store it? How do we facilitate our education function, and what is that function when you look at the committee's role to advise the select board? We need to know what we are talking about. Mr. Dempsey said SWAC won't tackle the issue now and thanked Ms. Litterst for it bringing up.

Setting Date for Next Meeting

John Dempsey pointed to conflicts around the June meeting date. He will send around an email with possible meeting dates. Maybe June 6? 6:30 PM

Other business

John Dempsey asked if SWAC should write a letter to Select Board advising them to consider raising cart rates by 2.5% to cover contract cost increases and inflation. What about charging for bulky waste instead? General consensus reached for John to draft a letter advising cart rate increase. Will confer with the commissioner before sending.

Mr. Johnson mentioned that next week is National Public Works Week. The DPW Open House is Thursday May 19th. He invited everyone to attend.

Adjournment: 8:07 PM

SWAC Meetings/Minutes Rotation – Updated as of 4/17/22

Kaity – 5/22

Mary – 6/22

Clint – 7/22

Deane – 8/22

Susan – 9/22

Kathleen – 10/22 John – 11/22